

SHINOTO: DISTANT PAST

Open on a shot of leather boots running on stone cobble. Cut to the face of the man running. It's an elf, face caked in dirt and blood. Lighting crashes in the background as wind and rain pelt the elf's face. Corpses litter the ground.

Elven Hero: BALTHAZAR!

The wind picks up as the weighty sound of flapping wings grows nearer, a gargantuan silhouette following close behind.

Balthazar: Foolish mortal!

The beast called Balthazar snarls. Lightning flashes in the sky, illuminating his true draconian form.

A ocarina of time esc boss text appears:

BALTHAZAR THE BRAZEN: SHAPE CHANGING SORCERER

Balthazar:

What hope have you against my scales of steel?
My wings of black and teeth like an eel?

Elven Hero:

I am but an elf, of flesh and of bone
But I have been tasked to save our dear home
With the oracle's blessing I shall stand
A fire in my heart and a sword in hand!

The elf goes in for the attack, swinging with all his might. The dragon swiftly dodges, and uses the miss as an opening for an attack. He pounces. The elf cries out in pain as Balthazar's razor sharp claws pin him to the ground. Blood may have been spilt, but the battle is far from won. The elf struggles against the beast's grip, and manages to snag an amulet from his belt. He lifts it to the dragon's eyes and wails:

Elven Hero: Take thine sight!

Suddenly, the amulet glows, and flashes a bright light. Balthazar howls in pain, dropping the elf as he moves to shield his reptilian eyes. The elf runs a short distance away.

Balthazar: Insolent pest!

Balthazar removes his claws from his face, revealing his now blinded eyes. The hero cautiously backs away, and accidentally steps on a branch that the ferocious wind had blown inside the castle walls. The branch crackles as it is split in two, the dragon's head snapping to the sound.

Balthazar: There you are!

Balthazar rushes the elf, but the elf thinks quickly.

Elven Hero: Fall like the feather!

The engravings on the elf's boots begin to glow, and with a single great leap, he sails right over the dragon. The elf spins in the air to face Balthazar, sliding backwards into the dirt as he lands. Balthazar roars in frustration. The beast takes a deep breath, and with a mighty bellow begins to spit fire from his frightful jaws. His head spins rapidly as he basks the castle walls in sweltering hellfire. The elf darts to and fro among the rising flames, sword in hand. The elf draws back his sword, and sets his sights for the dragon's cold heart.

Elven Hero: Strike like the lightning!

The sword begins to glow and whisper with a mysterious energy. The winds begin to change, swirling around it as it becomes brighter and brighter. Finally, with a mighty CRACK, a bolt of lightning hits the sword, imbuing it with electricity. With a guttural cry, the elf stabs his blade in the dragon's bosom. The air is deathly still. For a moment, there is silence. Then, the gargantuan frame of Balthazar the Brazen falls to the earth. It tries to get back up, but it can't.

Balthazar: This isn't over, mortal. I cast one more spell with my dying breath. I will be born again, in a different form, in a different place. If I cannot destroy you, then I will destroy your children, and if not them, then your children's children. Until fate immemorial I will continue to rise, if not to succeed, then to torment.

Elven Hero: So be it, beast. But I promise you, every time you return. No matter the form. No matter the place, there will always, ALWAYS, be someone like me to send you back to the hell to which you belong.

Balthazar: You-

Balthazar begins to hack violently, viscous bloody entrails ejecting from his maw.

Balthazar: you...

Balthazar finally falls to the ground, eyes wide open. The beast is dead. The elf breathes a sigh of relief. Cut to a wide shot of the castle, smoke pouring into the sky. The shot transitions to the castle during the day, the smoke fading with it.

Inside the castle walls, the elven hero stands in the bright daytime sun, his face marred with scars, but clean of blood. Fantastical creatures of all kinds surround him. He looks to his side. A beautiful elven woman stands there, crystal ball in hand. She gives him a fond smile. He returns it, and then turns to face his front. The King stands before him, his golden horn protruding through the crown that sits atop his skull.

King: At long last, the kingdoms will no longer be cast in the dark shadow of Balthazar the Brazen. This young man, championed by the Oracle, has done us a great deed, and it is my privilege to knight him as Hero of the Realm.

The elf kneels before the king, who takes out his sword. He gently rests the sword upon each of the elf's shoulders.

King: Words cannot express the depths of our gratitude. But alas, it appears this will not be the last we see of the dragon lord. It is foretold that he shall be reborn anew for each time he is slain. To combat our now eternal adversary, I declare that for each new generation, the Oracle will choose a new champion. A knight, to defend the realm from evil. A hero, to rise to the challenge of slaying Balthazar, Bane of evil, once more!

The crowd cheers as the camera pans upwards towards the sky.

SHINOTO: CURRENT DAY

Text appears on screen:

"300 years later"

The camera pans back down towards the castle, which has been placed in the center of a bustling metropolis made of oak and steel. The music is jaunty and modern, in contrast to the dramatic swells of before. The camera makes several cuts in succession: A griffin in a business suit walks along the sidewalk, chunky cell-phone in hand, oblivious to the mugging going on in the alley behind him. An electronic billboard advertising a pop star's new album, "Princess Problems". A variety of fantastical creatures all crammed into a subway car. A troll on board tries to stealthily eat one of the tiny fairies next to him. The fairy gives him a look. The troll quickly stops and looks away, mildly embarrassed. Cut to an exterior shot of the train car rolling past, revealing a crumbling apartment complex nestled beneath the roots of a monolithic oak tree, rotting from the inside out. Elevated train tracks run atop the roots of the tree, shaking the apartments nestled beneath them.

We focus on one unit in particular, located just below the tracks. Small offshoots from the giant root above hang over the rusted rod-iron of the balcony. Clothesline has been tied between the roots, a variety of colorful t-shirts haphazardly strung on it. As the train roars past, the entire building shakes. Clothes fall off the clothesline as the vibrations strum it like a guitar string. We take a closer look inside the unit, revealing a cramped apartment, approximately 15 square meters. The dwelling is messy, and disorganized. A half eaten PB&J sandwich sits on the dresser, along with a variety of comic books, all fantasy and science fiction. A small CRT, resembling a dingy mirror, sits in the corner, alongside a game console. The clothes hamper is overflowing with ragged, torn clothes. Posters of metal bands and cartoons line the walls. There's a floor mattress rolled out on the floor, its only occupant a well-loved chew toy.

Our focus is drawn to the old-school drawing desk, atop which is an imp, fast asleep. He looks a bit shabby, in his boxers patterned with

horned smiley faces and ill-fitted t-shirt. His fur is long and greasy. Bangs cover his eyes. He's drooling over a pile of half-finished drawings. Monsters, knights, comic pages, that sort of thing. Above the desk hangs a shelf, decorated with figurines and cheap snowglobes, as well as an old softball. The shelf shakes as the train cars above rattle the apartment, sending the softball careening onto the slumbering demon below.

Thump!

Max: "Ow!"

That sure woke him up. The imp rubs the top of his head, a bump surely starting to form. He spots the time on the analog alarm clock sitting on his desk. "1:15pm" it reads. We see his face as he looks at the clock, mouth half open, clearly still half asleep. Then, something clicks. His eyes widen.

Max: "Shit."

Cut to the apartment door as Max exits. He locks the door while putting one of his legs through a pair of dingy cargo pants, a sandwich wedged in his mouth. He's wearing a pair of wired earbuds, plugged into a MP3 player. He uses his clothed leg to hop to the stairwell, shoving his other leg in as he goes. At the top of the stairs, he trips on the bottom of his pant-leg, and falls forward towards the stairs. We cut to the bottom of the stairwell, itself leading out into the street. Muffled "thumps" and stars can be seen emerging from it. Max then stumbles out the door, now fully clothed, and manages to land on his feet. No time to lose, he starts jogging.

While jogging along the sidewalk, he dodges a variety of obstacles. A tall, skinny imp in a beanie takes out a gun to rob a convenience store, only for the blind old woman behind the counter to take out a massive sawed-off shotgun. She fires, hitting both the imp and the glass store front. Well, the glass that's left. One of the windows is covered in plywood. Max avoids the glass, shakes the debris off his sandwich, and takes a bite. A police officer with a medieval knight's helmet runs past. Max ducks under the spray of a fire hydrant, the hydrant itself having been hit by a red sports car. A police car is parked next to it. Seeing as the officer has run off to check out the convenience store, the woman inside puts her car in reverse, and starts to drive away. The officer runs back, yelling after her. Max then gets distracted by the newspapers sitting in front of the store.

Newspaper Headline 1: "HERO OF REALM STILL MISSING, CASE GONE COLD"

The first article reads: "There is still no news on the disappearance of our beloved Hero of the Realm. May his safe return be written in the sacred texts."

Newspaper Headline 2: "SUMMER BLOCKBUSTER BREAKS BOX OFFICE RECORDS"

This paper has an action movie poster printed on the front page. It features a large elf, wielding a giant Axe. The article reads: "

Last week marked the release of "Hero 2: with a vengeance. Starring Ace Wyrddwood." Due to the film's massive success, the studio has already started shooting the next film--"

The officer, having lost the woman in the red sports car, calls out to Max.

Officer: Hey! You there!

This snaps Max out of his stupor. He looks at his watch, and grimaces. He continues jogging, now at a much faster pace. He turns a corner, and the panel widens to reveal a massive base-ball stadium, a baseball game already well underway.

We cut back to Max as he attempts to stealthily slip in through a back door. The stadium's employee corridors are bustling with life, creatures of all shapes and sizes running every which way. Max tries his best to get through unscathed, but in his attempt to avoid getting run over by a hot-dog cart, he ends up falling right into someone else, and dumping their coffee all over their shirt. The someone else in question being a very large, very grumpy oni. He's wearing a button up shirt with a name tag clipped to it. It reads:

"監督- 荒悪鬼 / Manager- Araki".

Mr. Araki: "My office. NOW."

We cut to Max, sitting uncomfortably in a small folding chair. He's in a large, ornate office on one of the higher floors. Baseball trophies sit in a large, wood trophy case. Baseball memorabilia lines the walls. Light floods the room from the room's massive windows. A nice TV is mounted to the wall, playing a broadcast of the baseball game. It's on mute. Mr. Araki sits at a solid wood desk, towering over Max.

Mr. Araki: This is the 3rd time this week you've been late.

Max: 3 isn't so bad...

Mr. Araki: It's Tuesday.

Max: oh.

Mr. Araki: Sigh. Look, Max. I get it. You don't have the most prestigious job in the world. But I need you to face the facts. Not everyone can be the star pitcher. Not everyone can play in the field. Some of us are just destined for the bench, and that's ok. I know you have big dreams, but not everyone can be Ace Wyrddwood Max. The world isn't like the ones in comic books and video games. You need to be realistic. The sacred texts have a part for all of us, and this is yours. I know it's not the most glamorous fate, but someone has to do it.

Mr. Araki reaches under his desk, and brings out a large, goofy looking mascot head. It resembles a lion. He pushes it into Max's arms.

Mr. Araki: So get out there before the end of the second inning, before I decide your fate is *unemployment*!

Max gulps in fear.

We cut to Max a short time later, putting on the mascot head. The full costume is ridiculous, with big dopey eyes, a giant clown nose, and a long stuffed snake tail, complete with googly eyes. Max pushes open a door, and enters at the top of cheering baseball stands. He takes a step forward... onto the stuffed head of the costume's snake tail. He slips, and goes tumbling down the many, many, many stadium steps. After what feels like an eternity of falling, Max's costumed nose ends up buried in the grass of the baseball field with a disconcerting:

"THUMP!"

The stadium goes silent. Max gives a shaky thumbs up.

We then cut to a billboard attached to the side of a building, viewed through the panes of a large window. The billboard reads:

"The champion of the next generation. Watch, as the Oracle chooses the next hero of the realm. Tonight, only Lox".

The Lox logo resembles the Fox logo, only with a rapunzel-themed spin. We then cut to the one looking out the window. It's an elf, not too dissimilar to the elf in the prologue. His auburn hair spills onto his broad shoulders. Delicate hands adjust his suit jacket, dwarfed by his imposing frame. He looks to be the same elf featured in the newspaper movie advertisement. He looks distracted, staring at something hanging upon the wall of his penthouse apartment.

(Unseen Voice): Ace?

We cut to see what Ace is looking at. It's a painting of another elf. He looks like Ace, only older. He's holding the same sword shown in the prologue. We cut to the owner of the delicate hands, that being the kirin woman shown on the album billboard. She looks to be around the same age as Ace, and like him is also dressed in formal attire. She looks at Ace, and notices he is staring at the painting. She looks worried.

Kirin Woman: I'm sure he's proud of you, wherever he is.

Ace: Hah. I doubt it.

Kirin Woman: Oh come on, look at you! Descendant of champions. Action hero extraordinaire! Trusted confidante of the lovely Princess Yuzuki. (Gestures at self)

The room goes quiet.

Ace: They're going to start soon. We need to get going.

Ace exits the room. Yuzuki's fake smile fades. She looks more worried than before.

Cut to a shot of the sun setting over the city. A shadowy figure lurks the sidewalk as the street lights flicker to life. A akaname crawls out of a back-alley dumpster as if he were a feral racoon. Various neon lights and signs turn on. Cut to the castle, sun now fully set. Bright spotlights sway back and forth into the sky as the entrance is mobbed by press. An expensive car drives up to the castle doors. Camera bulbs flash and reporters chatter as Ace exits, and opens Yuzuki's door. The pair wave to the press like trained professionals, and make their way inside the castle walls. The inside of the castle is filled to the brim with various diplomats from distant lands. The Queen sits at the front of the room, a clear resemblance to both the king from the past, and Yuzuki. Next to her, the same oracle from

before, now shriveled and shrunken in her extreme old age. She is once again holding her crystal ball. Ace and Yuzuki approach them.

Yuzuki: Hello mother.

Queen Noriko: Yuzuki. Ace. It's good to see you.

Ace: Good to see you too, your highness.

Queen Noriko: Now that you are here, we can proceed.

Ace and Yuzuki step away from the queen and oracle.

Queen Noriko: Esteemed members of the court! I ask for your attention!

The crowd's chatter begins to die off as the ceremony starts.

Queen Noriko: It is with a heavy heart that I must call upon the oracle to choose a new hero of the realm. Bruce Wyrddwood was a brave and mighty hero, and a close personal friend. I can only hope our new champion may live up to his great legacy. Oracle, please reveal to us who is to become our new hero.

The oracle gives a sagely nod, and lifts her crystal ball upward. It begins to glow and whisper as it lifts into the air, lines of glowing symbols from the margins of the page reaching out towards it like tentacles. The oracle's eyes begin to glow as she begins the enchantment.

Oracle:

Sacred symbols and sigils of ours
Allow me to scry with your great powers
Grant me visage through time's thick haze
To choose a hero for the coming days

The winds swirl and spin as heavy clouds quickly roll in. The electric lights around the castle glow brighter and brighter, until they shatter from the force. The audience gasps. Ace looks to the ball, a look of both hope and desperation in his eyes.

Ace (quietly): Come on, come on-

The image in the ball swirls and shimmers, revealing the new hero to be:

Oracle: M A X B R I M S T O N E !

Ace: NO!

The crystal ball shows Max, holding a bag of ice to his head. He's taken off the mascot head, but is still wearing the rest of the suit. The crowd murmurs in confusion. Is this some sort of joke?

We cut to Mr. Araki, who was watching the broadcast on the TV in his office. He looks utterly horrified.

Mr. Araki: By the sacred texts. We're doomed.